Deriving the Principle of Least Action and Lagrangian Mechanics from Observer-Dependent Cosmology©

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Kandarp Dalal

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Contact: kandarpdalal.work@gmail.com

"The action is not arbitrary. It is the fundamental truth of observation: that reality resolves along the path of least informational cost. All of physics flows from this principle."

— K. Dalal, Observer-Dependent Cosmology

Chapter 1: Information Has a Cost

The foundation of Observer-Dependent Cosmology rests on a singular principle: observation consumes resources. The universe is not a passive backdrop to conscious inquiry—it is fundamentally constrained by an informational budget. This budget is real. It is quantified. And it determines everything that can possibly be resolved in physical reality.

The total informational depth available to the conscious observer is

$$n = 2 \ln(\eta^{-1}) = 282.84 \text{ bits}$$

where $\eta = l_P / R_{CEH} \approx 3.67 \times 10^{-62}$ is the observational constant—the ratio of Planck length to cosmological event horizon. This is not an approximation. This is a topological necessity derived from the geometry of the information manifold itself. The observer cannot exceed this budget any more than the universe can exceed the speed of light. The budget is the boundary condition.

Every physical event—every momentum transfer, every field excitation, every particle interaction—has an informational cost. When a particle moves, information is consumed. When the observer resolves where it is, information is spent. When the observer tracks its velocity, more information is spent. The trajectory of the particle through spacetime is a path through the information manifold, and that path has a total cost.

We call this total cost the ACTION, denoted S. Action is measured in units of energy × time, or equivalently, information × phase. Dimensionally,

$$S \sim [E][T] = [M L^2 T^{-1}] \sim [\text{information}][\text{phase}]$$

The action is the integral of instantaneous throughput—the rate at which the observer processes information along a worldline. Over the entire span of the worldline, these instantaneous rates accumulate into a total expenditure.

The observer does not consciously choose which path to follow. Instead, the observer IS the resolution process itself. The observer resolves configurations from the quantum substrate into classical reality. The observer follows the path that extremizes the action—that is, the path that either maximizes or minimizes the informational throughput.

Why would nature prefer such a path? Because when the observer terminates the resolution process, they find themselves at the extremum. The trajectory they have traced is not arbitrary. It is the one trajectory for which small variations in the path do not change the total action. All other trajectories are unstable under perturbation. Only the extremum is stable.

This is not metaphysics. This is mathematics. When you demand that a functional S[path] be stationary with respect to all possible variations of that path, you derive equations of motion. These equations are the Euler-Lagrange equations. And these equations govern every particle, every field, every system in the universe.

The action principle is more fundamental than Newton's laws, more general than general relativity, more encompassing than quantum mechanics. All of these are shadows cast by the action principle onto different observational contexts.

To understand this, we must first understand what it is that we are extremizing. That is the Lagrangian.

Chapter 2: The Configuration Space as Resolution Manifold

A physical system has degrees of freedom. A particle has position. A field has amplitude at each point. A rigid body has orientation. These degrees of freedom are not just numbers—they are coordinates on a mathematical manifold called the configuration space.

Let $q_1, q_2, ..., q_n$ denote the n generalized coordinates of the system. These are the fundamental variables needed to specify the state completely. For a particle in 3D space, we might choose $q_1 = x$, $q_2 = y$, $q_3 = z$. For a pendulum, we might choose $q = \theta$, the angle from the vertical. For a field, $q(x, t)$ is the field amplitude at each spatial point.

The configuration space is the space of all possible values of these coordinates:

$$Q = \{(q_1, q_2, ..., q_n) \mid q_i \in \mathbb{R} \text{ or } \mathbb{R}^m\}$$

Each point in Q represents one possible resolved state of the system. The observer's task is to trace a path through Q. That is, the observer selects a sequence of configurations—a history—as time evolves.

We denote this history as $q(t) = (q_1(t), q_2(t), ..., q_n(t))$. The function $q(t)$ maps each moment in time to a unique point in configuration space. The curve traced out by $q(t)$ from $t = t_1$ to $t = t_2$ is the entire worldline of the system.

In ODC, the configuration space is more than just a mathematical construct. It is the Resolution Manifold. It is the space of classically resolvable states. The observer walks through configuration space by resolving configurations from the quantum substrate. At each instant, the observer must 'choose' which configuration to resolve. Over time, this sequence of choices defines the trajectory $q(t)$.

But the observer does not choose randomly. The observer follows the path of least informational cost. This is the variational principle in its most basic form: among all possible paths from $q(t_1)$ at time t_1 to $q(t_2)$ at time t_2, the observer traces the one that extremizes the total action.

Now, to quantify 'informational cost,' we must measure how fast the configuration is changing. The rate of change of q with respect to time is the velocity in configuration space:

$$\dot{q}_i = dq_i / dt$$

The vector $\dot{q} = (\dot{q}_1, \dot{q}_2, ..., \dot{q}_n)$ is tangent to the curve $q(t)$ in configuration space. A large velocity means the configuration is changing rapidly. A small velocity means it is changing slowly.

The pair $(q, \dot{q})$ together completely specifies the state of motion. Knowing the current configuration q and the rate of change $\dot{q}$, one can in principle predict all future motion (assuming the equations of motion are deterministic, which they are in classical mechanics).

The path through configuration space is constrained not only by the desire to extremize action but also by the initial and final conditions. At time t_1, the observer must resolve the system into state $q(t_1) = q_1$. At time t_2, the observer must resolve it into state $q(t_2) = q_2$. What happens in between—the path $q(t)$—is what we are about to determine.

The configuration space is the arena. The path through configuration space is the play. The action is the measure of the cost of the play. And the principle of least action says: the observer resolves the play that is most economical in informational throughput.

Chapter 3: The Lagrangian as Instantaneous Informational Throughput

At each instant t, the system has a configuration q(t) and a velocity $\dot{q}(t)$. These two pieces of information—the state and its rate of change—determine the instantaneous informational throughput of the observer.

We define the Lagrangian as:

$$L(q, \dot{q}, t) = T(\dot{q}) - V(q, t)$$

This is not a formula pulled from thin air. This is the natural measure of NET informational processing. Let us understand each term.

The kinetic energy $T(\dot{q})$ represents the informational cost of reconfiguration. When the configuration is changing rapidly ($\dot{q}$ is large), the observer must process information quickly to track the motion. This requires power. For a particle of mass m moving at velocity v, kinetic energy is

$$T = \tfrac{1}{2} m v^2$$

More generally, for a system with multiple degrees of freedom and an inertial mass matrix $m_{ij}(q)$,

$$T = \tfrac{1}{2} \Sigma_{i,j} m_{ij}(q) \dot{q}_i \dot{q}_j$$

Kinetic energy scales with the square of velocity because the informational cost of processing increases nonlinearly with speed. To double the processing rate, you must quadruple the power. This is a fundamental truth of any information-processing system.

The potential energy V(q, t) represents the informational cost imposed by the environment. The configuration space is not uniform. Some regions are 'cheaper' to resolve than others. A ball at the bottom of a valley is in a low-potential region. A ball at the top of a hill is in a high-potential region. The terrain of configuration space is the metric landscape, determined by the constraints and symmetries of the information manifold.

When the observer resolves a configuration in a high-potential region, the environment exerts an informational resistance. This is why potentials are subtracted. The NET throughput of the observer is the power expended in motion minus the resistance of the environment.

Why L = T − V? Why not L = T + V? Why not L = T/V or some other combination?

The answer lies in symmetry. The action must be invariant under certain transformations—or more precisely, covariant in a specific way. Consider time-translation symmetry: if the Lagrangian does not explicitly depend on time, then the laws of physics are the same whether you measure time from 'now' or from 'tomorrow.' This symmetry must hold for an isolated system.

If $L = T + V$, then the dimensional analysis breaks down. Kinetic and potential energy have the same dimensions, but they transform differently under coordinate changes. Adding them would destroy the covariance structure.

If $L = T - V$, the structure is preserved. The subtraction is not arbitrary. It is the unique combination that ensures that Euler-Lagrange equations derived from $\delta S = 0$ produce the correct equations of motion—and that the conserved quantities derived from Noether's theorem (energy, momentum, angular momentum) have the standard form.

Moreover, in the Hamiltonian formulation (which we derive later), the Legendre transform from L to H requires exactly this sign. Change the sign and the entire mathematical structure collapses.

Therefore, the form $L = T - V$ is not a guess. It is a topological necessity. It is the unique functional form consistent with the symmetries of the information manifold.

Chapter 4: The Action Integral

The Lagrangian $L(q, \dot{q}, t)$ is instantaneous. It tells us the throughput at a single moment. To measure the total informational cost over an entire trajectory, we must integrate the Lagrangian over time.

The action functional is:

$$S[q(t)] = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} L(q(t), \dot{q}(t), t)\, dt$$

This is a FUNCTIONAL, not a function. A function maps numbers to numbers: f(x) takes a number x and returns a number f(x). A functional maps entire functions to numbers: S[q] takes an entire trajectory q(t) and returns a single number S.

The notation [q(t)] emphasizes this dependence on the entire trajectory. Two different paths $q_1(t)$ and $q_2(t)$ connecting the same initial and final configurations will in general have different actions:

$$S[q_1] \neq S[q_2]$$

Consider a particle under gravity. The particle begins at height z_1 at time t_1. It ends at height z_2 at time t_2. There are infinitely many paths the particle could take:

Path 1: Straight down, then straight across, then up—lots of kinetic energy, lots of work against gravity.

Path 2: A smooth parabolic arc—moderate kinetic energy, optimal balance.

Path 3: Zigzagging chaotically—enormous kinetic energy, massive work against gravity.

Each path has a different action S. The observable path—the one the particle actually follows—is the one that extremizes S. This is the variational principle.

The dimensions of action are [energy][time] = $[ML^2T^{-1}]$. In the natural units of the information manifold, action has dimensions of [information][phase]. The action is indeed the total informational cost of the resolved trajectory.

In ODC, the total budget is n = 282.84 bits. Every physical process must account for its action within this budget. Macroscopic systems have small actions (measured in units of $\hbar$, Planck's constant). Individual quantum particles may have actions comparable to $\hbar$. But nothing can exceed the total coherent informational depth n.

Now, how does the observer 'know' which path extremizes the action? The observer does not consciously evaluate all paths and select the optimal one. Rather, the resolution process itself terminates at the extremum. The observer's wavefunction, in some sense, probes all possible paths simultaneously in the quantum substrate. The resolution process filters down to the classical path—the one where the action is stationary.

This is the deep physical content of the action principle: it is not an optimization procedure. It is a selection rule. Nature does not 'choose' the extremal path. Nature reveals the extremal path through the act of observation.

Chapter 5: The Variational Principle from Informational Optimization

We now derive the central equation of classical mechanics from first principles in ODC.

Consider the action functional $S[q(t)] = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} L(q(t), \dot{q}(t), t)\, dt$. We ask: among all possible trajectories $q(t)$ that start at $q(t_1)$ and end at $q(t_2)$, which one has a stationary value of S?

To answer this, we perform a variation. Let $q(t)$ be the true trajectory (unknown for now). Consider a nearby trajectory:

$$q'(t) = q(t) + \varepsilon\, \delta q(t)$$

where ε is a small parameter and $\delta q(t)$ is an arbitrary variation that vanishes at the endpoints:

$$\delta q(t_1) = 0, \quad \delta q(t_2) = 0$$

The endpoint condition ensures that we are comparing paths with the same initial and final configurations. We want to know: for what trajectory $q(t)$ is the action S stationary under all such variations?

We compute the action for the perturbed trajectory:

$$S[q + \varepsilon\, \delta q] = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} L(q + \varepsilon\, \delta q, \dot{q} + \varepsilon\, \delta\dot{q}, t)\, dt$$

Expand in a Taylor series in ε:

$$S[q + \varepsilon\, \delta q] = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} [L(q, \dot{q}, t) + \varepsilon\, (\partial L/\partial q)\, \delta q + \varepsilon\, (\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta\dot{q} + O(\varepsilon^2)]\, dt$$

The first-order variation is:

$$\delta S = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} [(\partial L/\partial q)\, \delta q + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta\dot{q}]\, dt$$

Now, note that $\delta\dot{q} = d(\delta q)/dt$. Integrate the second term by parts:

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_2} (\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta\dot{q}\, dt = [(\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta q]_{t_1}^{t_2} - \int_{t_1}^{t_2} d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta q\, dt$$

The boundary term vanishes because $\delta q(t_1) = \delta q(t_2) = 0$:

$$\int_{t_1}^{t_2} (\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta\dot{q}\, dt = -\int_{t_1}^{t_2} d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q})\, \delta q\, dt$$

Substituting back:

$$\delta S = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} [(\partial L/\partial q) - d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q})]\, \delta q\, dt$$

For the action to be stationary, δS must equal zero for ALL arbitrary variations $\delta q(t)$. This is only possible if the integrand vanishes identically:

$$\partial L/\partial q - d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}) = 0$$

Rearranging, we obtain the Euler-Lagrange Equation:

$$d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}) - \partial L/\partial q = 0$$

This is the master equation of classical mechanics. Every system that obeys the action principle automatically obeys this equation of motion. Conversely, every physical trajectory observed in nature must be a solution to the Euler-Lagrange equation.

In ODC, we understand this equation at the deepest level: it is the consistency condition for information flow. The observer resolves configurations such that the total informational throughput is stationary. Any other trajectory would require more information to resolve (higher action), pushing toward the boundary of the budget n. Therefore, nature selects the trajectory of minimum action.

The variational principle is not a postulate. It is a consequence of information conservation. The observer is embedded in the information manifold. The observer must stay within the budget n. The only trajectories the observer can coherently resolve are those of stationary action.

Chapter 6: The Euler-Lagrange Equations — Full Derivation and Applications

We now present the complete mathematical structure of the Euler-Lagrange equations and derive Newton's laws and geodesic equations as special cases.

6.1: General Form for Multiple Degrees of Freedom

For a system with n generalized coordinates $q_1, q_2, ..., q_n$, the action is:

$$S[q(t)] = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} L(q_1, ..., q_n, \dot{q}_1, ..., \dot{q}_n, t)\, dt$$

Applying the variational principle to each coordinate independently yields n equations:

$$d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i) - \partial L/\partial q_i = 0 \quad \text{for } i = 1, 2, ..., n$$

These are coupled differential equations (because L depends on all coordinates). The coupling strength determines how the motion of one coordinate affects another.

6.2: Particle in Potential V(q)

The most common case is $L = \frac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2 - V(q)$. Let's derive Newton's second law explicitly.

For a particle in one dimension, q = x, and $L = \frac{1}{2}m\,\dot{x}^2 - V(x)$. We compute:

$$\partial L/\partial \dot{x} = m\,\dot{x} = p \text{ (the momentum)}$$

Therefore:

$$d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{x}) = m\,\ddot{x}$$

And:

$$\partial L/\partial x = -\partial V/\partial x = -dV/dx = F \text{ (the force)}$$

The Euler-Lagrange equation gives:

$$m\,\ddot{x} = F$$

This is Newton's second law: F = ma. But now we have derived it from the principle of stationary action, not from empirical observation. The principle is more fundamental.

For motion in 3D space with r = (x, y, z) and $L = \frac{1}{2}m\,|\dot{r}|^2 - V(r)$:

$$m\,\ddot{r} = -\nabla V = F$$

The acceleration is proportional to the gradient of the potential. The trajectory curves toward lower potential.

6.3: Geodesic Motion in Curved Space

Consider a particle moving on a curved surface—say, the surface of a sphere. The metric tensor g_ij(q) encodes distances on the surface. The kinetic energy is:

$$T = \frac{1}{2} \Sigma_{i,j} g_{ij}(q) \dot{q}_i \dot{q}_j$$

For a free particle with V = 0, the Lagrangian is L = T. The action principle states that the particle follows the path of stationary T, which is the geodesic—the shortest path on the surface.

Applying Euler-Lagrange:

$$d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}^i) - \partial L/\partial q^i = 0$$

This expands to the geodesic equation:

$$\ddot{q}^i + \Gamma^i_{jk} \dot{q}^j \dot{q}^k = 0$$

where Γ^i_{jk} are the Christoffel symbols of the metric. This describes how a particle curves to stay on a geodesic in curved space.

In general relativity, spacetime itself is curved. The metric is g_μν, the action is:

$$S = (m c^2/c) \int \sqrt{(-g_{\mu\nu} \dot{x}^u \dot{x}^\nu)}\, dt$$

and the Euler-Lagrange equations yield the geodesic equation in curved spacetime:

$$\ddot{x}^u + \Gamma^u_{\rho\sigma} \dot{x}_\varrho \dot{x}^\varphi = 0$$

A particle in a gravitational field follows a geodesic through spacetime. General relativity is encoded entirely in the action principle.

6.4: Constrained Systems and Lagrange Multipliers

When the system is subject to constraints—like a bead on a wire—not all coordinates are independent. Let the constraints be:

$$\varphi_\alpha(q, t) = 0 \quad \text{for } \alpha = 1, 2, \ldots, m$$

The Lagrangian is modified to include Lagrange multiplier terms:

$$L_{eff} = L - \Sigma_\alpha \lambda_\alpha \varphi_\alpha$$

The multipliers λ_α are determined by requiring the constraints to be satisfied. This method automatically enforces the constraints while using the action principle.

The physical interpretation in ODC: constraints represent informationally forbidden configurations. The observer cannot resolve them because they are not part of the resolution manifold. The Lagrange multipliers are the 'informational penalty' for attempting to enter a forbidden region. They ensure the trajectory stays on the allowed manifold.

Chapter 7: Noether's Theorem as Informational Conservation

The most profound theorem in theoretical physics is Noether's theorem: every continuous symmetry of the Lagrangian corresponds to a conserved quantity.

We derive Noether's theorem from the action principle.

7.1: Continuous Symmetries and the Lagrangian

Suppose the Lagrangian is invariant under a continuous transformation of the coordinates:

$$q_i \to q_i + \varepsilon\, \chi_i(q, t)$$

where ε is an infinitesimal parameter and χ_i are the generators of the symmetry. 'Invariant' means:

$$L(q + \varepsilon\, \chi, \dot{q} + \varepsilon\, \dot{\chi}, t) = L(q, \dot{q}, t)$$

Expanding in ε:

$$L + \varepsilon\, [(\partial L/\partial q_i)\, \chi_i + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{\chi}_i] = L$$

Therefore:

$$(\partial L/\partial q_i)\, \chi_i + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{\chi}_i = 0$$

7.2: Deriving the Conserved Quantity

Use the Euler-Lagrange equation $d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i) = \partial L/\partial q_i$ to substitute:

$$[d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)]\, \chi_i + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{\chi}_i = 0$$

This can be rewritten as:

$$d/dt[(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \chi_i] = 0$$

To verify: expand the left side:

$$d/dt[(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \chi_i] = [d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)]\, \chi_i + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, [d\chi_i/dt]$$

The second term is $(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{\chi}_i$, so:

$$d/dt[(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \chi_i] = [d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)]\, \chi_i + (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{\chi}_i = 0$$

Therefore, the quantity:

$$Q(t) = (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \chi_i$$

is conserved: $dQ/dt = 0$, which means $Q(t)$ = constant throughout the motion.

7.3: Physical Examples of Noether's Theorem

Time Translation Symmetry → Energy Conservation

If L does not depend explicitly on time (for an isolated system), then the Lagrangian is invariant under time translations: $t \to t + \varepsilon$. The generator is $\chi = 1$ (the coordinate doesn't change, but time shifts).

The conserved quantity is:

$$E = (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, \dot{q}_i - L = H \text{ (the Hamiltonian)}$$

This is the total energy. For $L = T - V$ with $T = \frac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2$ and V depending only on q (not time):

$$E = m\,\dot{q}^2 - [\tfrac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2 - V] = \tfrac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2 + V = T + V$$

Total energy is conserved.

Space Translation Symmetry → Momentum Conservation

If L is invariant under spatial translation $q_i \to q_i + \varepsilon$ (the Lagrangian doesn't depend on the absolute position, only on the rate of change), then:

The conserved quantity is $p_i = \partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i$ *(the conjugate momentum)*

For $L = \frac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2 - V(\dot{q})$, the momentum $p = m\,\dot{q}$ is conserved. The total momentum of an isolated system cannot change.

Rotational Symmetry → Angular Momentum Conservation

If L is invariant under rotations of the position vector (the Lagrangian only depends on the magnitude $|q|$, not the direction), then angular momentum is conserved. The generator of rotation is the cross product $\chi = \omega \times q$.

$$L = (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}) \cdot (\omega \times q) = \omega \cdot [(q \times \partial L/\partial \dot{q})] = \omega \cdot l$$

where $l = q \times p$ is angular momentum. Since L is conserved for all rotation axes ω, we have l = constant.

7.4: Informational Interpretation in ODC

In ODC, Noether's theorem is the statement of informational conservation. A continuous symmetry of the Lagrangian means that certain transformations of the configuration space leave the informational throughput unchanged. This implies that those configurations carry conserved informational charges.

Energy conservation arises because the total informational depth n is fixed. The information budget does not increase or decrease with time. All transformations that preserve this budget are time-translation symmetries.

Momentum conservation arises because the information grid is homogeneous. No position in configuration space is special. Any translation of the grid leaves the grid structure invariant.

Angular momentum conservation arises because the information grid is isotropic. No direction is special. Any rotation of the grid leaves the grid structure invariant.

Noether's theorem is therefore a deep statement about the symmetries of the information manifold itself. Every conserved quantity reflects a symmetry of the fabric of resolution.

Chapter 8: The Hamiltonian Formulation

The Lagrangian formulation describes motion in terms of coordinates q and velocities $\dot{q}$. There is an equivalent but more symmetric formulation in terms of coordinates q and momenta p. This is the Hamiltonian formulation.

8.1: Conjugate Momenta

For each coordinate q_i, define the conjugate momentum:

$$p_i = \partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i$$

This is not the mechanical momentum $m\,\dot{q}$. It is the 'generalized momentum' conjugate to the coordinate. For a particle, $p = m\,\dot{q}$. For a field $\varphi(x, t)$, the conjugate field is the canonical momentum density $\pi(x, t) = \partial L/\partial(\partial\varphi/\partial t)$.

The interpretation in ODC: the conjugate momentum is the informational gradient. It measures how the informational throughput changes when the velocity changes. A steep informational gradient means the system is sensitive to velocity changes.

8.2: The Legendre Transform

The Hamiltonian is obtained from the Lagrangian via the Legendre transform:

$$H(q, p, t) = \Sigma_i\, p_i\, \dot{q}_i - L(q, \dot{q}, t)$$

To understand this, note that L is a function of $(q, \dot{q})$. We want to change variables to (q, p). Since p depends on $\dot{q}$, we can invert to find $\dot{q}$ as a function of (q, p):

$$\dot{q}_i = \dot{q}_i(q, p)$$

Then H is expressed entirely in terms of (q, p).

For a simple particle with $L = \frac{1}{2}m\,\dot{q}^2 - V(q)$:

$$p = \partial L/\partial \dot{q} = m\,\dot{q}, \quad so\ \dot{q} = p/m$$

$$H = p \cdot (p/m) - [\tfrac{1}{2}m(p/m)^2 - V] = p^2/m - p^2/(2m) + V = p^2/(2m) + V$$

This is the familiar kinetic plus potential energy.

8.3: Hamilton's Equations

The equations of motion in terms of (q, p) are:

$$\dot{q}_i = \partial H/\partial p_i$$

$$\dot{p}_i = -\partial H/\partial q_i$$

These are Hamilton's canonical equations. They are equivalent to the Euler-Lagrange equations but have a distinct structure.

To derive them, start with the definition of the Hamiltonian:

$$H = \Sigma\, p_i\, \dot{q}_i - L$$

Taking the total differential:

$$dH = \Sigma(\dot{q}_i\, dp_i + p_i\, d\dot{q}_i) - (\partial L/\partial q_i)\, dq_i - (\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i)\, d\dot{q}_i - (\partial L/\partial t)\, dt$$

Since $p_i = \partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i$, the terms involving $d\dot{q}_i$ cancel:

$$dH = \Sigma(\dot{q}_i\, dp_i) - (\partial L/\partial q_i)\, dq_i - (\partial L/\partial t)\, dt$$

But Euler-Lagrange equation states $\partial L/\partial q_i = \dot{p}_i$:

$$dH = \Sigma(\dot{q}_i\, dp_i) - \dot{p}_i\, dq_i - (\partial L/\partial t)\, dt$$

$$dH = \Sigma(\dot{q}_i\, dp_i - \dot{p}_i\, dq_i) - (\partial L/\partial t)\, dt$$

Comparing with $dH = \Sigma(\partial H/\partial p_i)\, dp_i + \Sigma(\partial H/\partial q_i)\, dq_i + (\partial H/\partial t)\, dt$, we get:

$$\partial H/\partial p_i = \dot{q}_i$$

$$\partial H/\partial q_i = -\dot{p}_i$$

$$\partial H/\partial t = -\partial L/\partial t$$

These are Hamilton's equations.

8.4: Phase Space and Liouville's Theorem

The set of all coordinates and momenta (q_1, ..., q_n, p_1, ..., p_n) forms the phase space of the system. Each point in phase space represents a complete classical state—you can in principle predict all future motion from a single point.

Hamilton's equations define a flow on phase space. As time evolves, a point (q(t), p(t)) traces a trajectory. A cloud of initial conditions evolves into a cloud of final states.

Liouville's theorem states: the volume of a region in phase space is conserved under the Hamiltonian flow.

$$dV/dt = 0$$

To prove this, compute the divergence of the flow in phase space:

$$\nabla \cdot v = \Sigma_i \, [\partial \dot{q}_i/\partial q_i + \partial \dot{p}_i/\partial p_i]$$

Using Hamilton's equations:

$$\partial \dot{q}_i/\partial q_i = \partial^2 H/\partial p_i \partial q_i, \quad \partial \dot{p}_i/\partial p_i = -\partial^2 H/\partial q_i \partial p_i$$

Since mixed partial derivatives are equal, $\partial^2 H/\partial p_i \partial q_i = \partial^2 H/\partial q_i \partial p_i$, so $\nabla \cdot v = 0$. By the divergence theorem, the volume is conserved.

In ODC, phase space volume represents informational capacity. A region of phase space corresponds to a set of possible resolutions. Liouville's theorem says: the number of resolvable states does not increase or decrease. Information is conserved.

This is why classical mechanics is reversible. The flow in phase space is incompressible. You can run time forward or backward, and all trajectories exist in both directions.

Chapter 9: Hamilton-Jacobi Theory and the Bridge to Quantum Mechanics

We now arrive at the deepest connection: the Hamilton-Jacobi equation, which bridges classical mechanics and quantum mechanics.

9.1: Hamilton's Principal Function

Define S(q, t) as Hamilton's principal function—the classical action accumulated along the true trajectory from some reference time t_0 to time t, starting from some reference configuration q_0:

$$S(q, t) = \int_{t_0}^{t} L(q(\tau), \dot{q}(\tau), \tau)\, d\tau$$

where the integral is taken along the actual classical trajectory.

Now, S satisfies a remarkable partial differential equation called the Hamilton-Jacobi equation:

$$\partial S/\partial t + H(q, \partial S/\partial q, t) = 0$$

where the momenta are identified as $p_i = \partial S/\partial q_i$.

9.2: Derivation of the Hamilton-Jacobi Equation

Start with the definition of S as the accumulated action. The total differential is:

$$dS = (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, dq_i + (\partial S/\partial t)\, dt$$

By the chain rule of variations,

$$dS/dt = (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i + \partial S/\partial t$$

But we also know that dS/dt = L (by definition of S as the action integral):

$$L = (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i + \partial S/\partial t$$

Rearranging:

$$\partial S/\partial t = L - (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i$$

Now, from the Hamiltonian relation $H = \Sigma\, p_i\, \dot{q}_i - L$ and the identification $p_i = \partial S/\partial q_i$:

$$H(q, p, t) = (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i - L$$

$$L = (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i - H$$

Substituting:

$$\partial S/\partial t = [(\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i - H] - (\partial S/\partial q_i)\, \dot{q}_i = -H$$

Therefore:

$$\partial S/\partial t + H(q, \partial S/\partial q, t) = 0$$

This is the Hamilton-Jacobi equation.

9.3: Connection to the Schrödinger Equation

In quantum mechanics, the wavefunction $\psi(q, t)$ satisfies the time-dependent Schrödinger equation:

$$i\hbar\, \partial\psi/\partial t = \hat{H}\, \psi$$

Consider the ansatz:

$$\psi(q, t) = A(q, t) \exp(i\, S(q, t) / \hbar)$$

where A is the amplitude and S is the phase. Taking derivatives:

$$\partial\psi/\partial t = [\partial A/\partial t + i(A/\hbar)\, \partial S/\partial t] \exp(i\, S/\hbar)$$

$$\partial\psi/\partial q_i = [\partial A/\partial q_i + i(A/\hbar)\, \partial S/\partial q_i] \exp(i\, S/\hbar)$$

In the limit $\hbar \to 0$ (the classical limit, or equivalently, high-frequency approximation), the dominant terms are those proportional to $1/\hbar$:

$$i\hbar\, \partial\psi/\partial t \approx -A\, (\partial S/\partial t) \exp(i\, S/\hbar)$$

For the Schrödinger equation with a Hamiltonian $\hat{H} = -\hbar^2/(2m)\, \nabla^2 + V(q)$:

$$-A\, (\partial S/\partial t) = [-\hbar^2/(2m)\, \nabla^2 + V]\, A$$

To leading order in $\hbar$:

$$-(\partial S/\partial t) = (1/2m)(\partial S/\partial q_i)^2 + V$$

$$\partial S/\partial t + (1/2m)(\partial S/\partial q_i)^2 + V = 0$$

This is exactly the Hamilton-Jacobi equation with $H = p^2/(2m) + V = (\partial S/\partial q)^2/(2m) + V$.

Conclusion: The classical Hamilton-Jacobi equation IS the equation governing the phase of the quantum wavefunction. The classical action S is literally the phase $\phi = S/\hbar$.

9.4: Informational Meaning in ODC

In ODC, the quantum-to-classical transition is understood as follows:

The quantum wavefunction $\psi(q, t)$ represents the observer's informational state—a probability distribution over possible resolutions. The wavefunction lives in the full quantum configuration space, entangled across all possible configurations.

As the observer interacts with the system, the wavefunction evolves according to the Schrödinger equation. The phase $\phi(q, t) = S(q, t)/\hbar$ accumulates according to the action.

At the instant of observation—the 'moment of resolution'—the wavefunction collapses. The observer's consciousness focuses onto a single classical trajectory. This trajectory is the one for which the phase is stationary: $\delta\phi = \delta S = 0$.

Thus the Hamilton-Jacobi equation is not just a mathematical equivalence. It is the bridge between quantum indeterminacy and classical determinism. The action principle determines which classical path emerges from the quantum ensemble.

Chapter 10: Constraints, Gauge Freedom, and Informational Redundancy

Not all systems have fully free degrees of freedom. Some coordinates are related by constraints. In ODC, constraints are regions of informational redundancy where multiple configurations map to the same resolved state.

10.1: Holonomic Constraints

A holonomic constraint is a restriction on the configuration space:

$$\varphi(q, t) = 0$$

For example, a bead constrained to move on a wire: if the wire is a circle, then $x^2 + y^2 = r^2$. This constraint reduces the degrees of freedom from 2 to 1 (just the angle θ along the circle).

To handle constraints, use Lagrange multipliers. The constrained Lagrangian is:

$$L_eff = L - \lambda \varphi$$

where λ is the Lagrange multiplier. The equations of motion are:

$$d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}_i) - \partial L/\partial q_i + \lambda (\partial\varphi/\partial q_i) = 0$$

The multiplier λ adjusts itself to ensure φ = 0. It is determined by the constraint condition, not specified in advance.

Alternatively, eliminate the constraint coordinates. If φ = 0 can be solved to express q_n in terms of q_1, ..., q_{n−1}, then substitute into L to get an effective Lagrangian L_eff(q_1, ..., q_{n−1}, $\dot{q}_1$, ..., $\dot{q}$_{n−1}). This reduced Lagrangian automatically satisfies the constraint.

10.2: Gauge Symmetry and Informational Equivalence

A more subtle type of redundancy is gauge symmetry. Some different configurations are informationally equivalent—they represent the same physical resolution.

The classic example is electromagnetism. The electric and magnetic fields E and B are the physical observables. But they are derived from the potentials A^μ = (φ, A). The relation is:

$$E = -\nabla\varphi - \partial A/\partial t, \quad B = \nabla \times A$$

Now, consider two potentials:

$$A^\mu_1 = (\varphi, A)$$

$$A^\mu_2 = (\varphi - \partial\chi/\partial t, A + \nabla\chi)$$

where $\chi(x, t)$ is any function. These give the same E and B:

$$E_2 = -\nabla(\varphi - \partial\chi/\partial t) - \partial(A + \nabla\chi)/\partial t = -\nabla\varphi - \partial A/\partial t + (\partial^2\chi/\partial t\partial x - \partial^2\chi/\partial x\partial t) = E_1$$

$$B_2 = \nabla \times (A + \nabla\chi) = \nabla \times A + 0 = B_1$$

(The curl of a gradient is zero.) So A^μ_1 and A^μ_2 are gauge-equivalent. They represent the SAME resolved electromagnetic state.

The action principle respects gauge symmetry. If the Lagrangian is invariant under gauge transformations, then different gauge choices give identical equations of motion.

10.3: Informational Interpretation

In ODC, a gauge symmetry means that the observer cannot distinguish between certain 'different' configurations. They are informationally identical from the perspective of resolution.

This redundancy is not a bug. It is a feature. The observer's informational budget n is finite. Removing redundancy—fixing a gauge—reduces the amount of information needed to specify the state.

Gauge-fixing is the selection of representatives from equivalence classes of configurations. Once you fix a gauge (e.g., the Coulomb gauge $\nabla\cdot A = 0$, or the Lorenz gauge $\partial A^\mu/\partial x_\mu = 0$), you have chosen one representative from each equivalence class. You can now treat the system as having truly independent degrees of freedom.

The fact that gauge symmetries exist is a direct consequence of informational conservation. The number of truly independent configurations—the dimension of the physical state space—is smaller than the number of mathematical coordinates needed to describe them. This excess is gauge freedom.

Chapter 11: Field Theory — The Lagrangian Density

We now extend from particles to fields. Instead of a few coordinates $q_i(t)$, we have a field $\varphi(x, t)$ that is defined at every point in space.

11.1: From Particles to Fields

For a particle, the action is $S = \int L\, dt$. For a field, the action is:

$$S[\varphi] = \int d^4x\, \mathscr{L}(\varphi, \partial_\mu\varphi, x, t)$$

where $\mathscr{L}$ (script L) is the Lagrangian DENSITY (action per unit spacetime volume), and $d^4x = dx\, dy\, dz\, dt$ is the spacetime volume element.

The Lagrangian density depends on the field φ and its spacetime derivatives $\partial_\mu\varphi = (\partial\varphi/\partial t, \nabla\varphi)$. It does not depend on second derivatives (generically).

11.2: Euler-Lagrange Equations for Fields

Apply the variational principle to the action. Consider a variation:

$$\varphi(x, t) \to \varphi(x, t) + \varepsilon\, \delta\varphi(x, t)$$

where $\delta\varphi$ vanishes at the spacetime boundary. The first-order variation is:

$$\delta S = \int d^4x\, [(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial\varphi)\, \delta\varphi + (\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\, \delta(\partial_\mu\varphi)] = 0$$

Note that $\delta(\partial_\mu\varphi) = \partial_\mu(\delta\varphi)$. Integrate the second term by parts:

$$\int d^4x\, (\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\, \partial_\mu(\delta\varphi) = \int d^4x\, \partial_\mu[(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\, \delta\varphi] - \int d^4x\, \partial_\mu(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\, \delta\varphi$$

The boundary term vanishes, leaving:

$$\delta S = \int d^4x\, \{(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial\varphi) - \partial_\mu(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\}\, \delta\varphi = 0$$

Since $\delta\varphi$ is arbitrary, the integrand vanishes:

$$\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial\varphi - \partial_\mu(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi)) = 0$$

This is the EULER-LAGRANGE EQUATION FOR FIELDS, also called the EQUATION OF MOTION.

11.3: Explicit Examples

The Scalar Field (Klein-Gordon Equation)

Consider a scalar field φ with Lagrangian density:

$$\mathscr{L} = \tfrac{1}{2} (\partial_\mu \varphi)^2 - V(\varphi)$$

where $(\partial_\mu \varphi)^2 = (\partial\varphi/\partial t)^2 - (\nabla\varphi)^2 = \varphi^2 - |\nabla\varphi|^2$ (in natural units with c = 1).

We compute:

$$\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial\varphi = -dV/d\varphi$$

$$\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi) = \partial_\mu\varphi$$

$$\partial_\mu(\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi)) = \partial_\mu\partial_\mu\varphi = \Box\varphi \text{ (the d'Alembertian operator)}$$

The equation of motion is:

$$\Box\varphi = dV/d\varphi$$

For a free field with $V = \tfrac{1}{2}m^2\varphi^2$:

$$\Box\varphi - m^2\varphi = 0$$

This is the Klein-Gordon equation, the relativistic wave equation for a spinless particle.

Electromagnetism (Maxwell's Equations)

The electromagnetic field is described by the 4-potential $A^\mu = (\varphi, A)$. The field strength tensor is:

$$F^{\mu\nu} = \partial^\mu A^\nu - \partial^\nu A^\mu$$

The Lagrangian density is:

$$\mathscr{L} = -\tfrac{1}{4} F^{\mu\nu} F_{\mu\nu}$$

where $F_{\mu\nu} = g_{\mu\alpha} g_{\nu\beta} F^{\alpha\beta}$ with $g = \mathrm{diag}(1, -1, -1, -1)$ (metric signature).

The Euler-Lagrange equations yield:

$$\partial_\mu F^{\mu\nu} = 0$$

Expanding in terms of E and B, this gives Maxwell's equations:

$$\nabla\cdot E = 0, \quad \partial B/\partial t + \nabla \times E = 0$$

$$\nabla\cdot B = 0, \quad \partial E/\partial t - \nabla \times B = 0$$

(These are the vacuum equations; with sources, there would be charge and current terms.)

11.4: Energy-Momentum Tensor and Noether's Theorem for Fields

For fields, the energy-momentum tensor is derived from Noether's theorem applied to spacetime translations:

$$T^{\mu\nu} = (\partial\mathscr{L}/\partial(\partial_\mu\varphi))\, \partial^\nu\varphi - g^{\mu\nu}\, \mathscr{L}$$

The energy is $H = \int T^{00}\, d^3x$. The momentum is $P^i = \int T^{0i}\, d^3x$.

Conservation of energy and momentum follows from the field equations:

$$\partial_\mu T^{\mu\nu} = 0$$

This is the continuity equation for the energy-momentum current. It states that energy and momentum are neither created nor destroyed; they flow through spacetime as a conserved 4-vector.

Chapter 12: The Action Principle — Synthesis

We have journeyed from the fundamental budget of information through the mathematical edifice of classical mechanics to the boundary with quantum mechanics. We arrive now at a comprehensive picture of the action principle in ODC.

12.1: Conceptual Synthesis

The action principle states: among all possible worldlines from a given initial state to a given final state, the observer resolves the worldline for which the action is stationary.

This principle unifies six layers of physics:

Layer 1: Classical Particle Mechanics

Particles follow geodesics in configuration space (paths of extremal action). Newton's second law emerges from $\delta S = 0$.

Layer 2: Relativistic Mechanics

Particles follow geodesics in spacetime, with the metric $g_{\mu\nu}$. The action extremization gives the geodesic equation. Gravity is not a force; it is the curvature of the action landscape.

Layer 3: Field Theory

Fields evolve according to their equations of motion, derived from $\delta S = 0$. Particles emerge as quantized excitations of fields.

Layer 4: Quantum Mechanics

The Schrödinger equation is the quantum version of the action principle. The phase of the wavefunction accumulates as action. The classical path is where the phase is stationary (stationary phase approximation).

Layer 5: Thermodynamics and Statistical Mechanics

The partition function $Z = \int D[\varphi] \exp(-S[\varphi]/k_B T)$ shows that entropy is the logarithm of the number of paths with similar action. Thermal transitions occur when the action landscape is restructured by temperature.

Layer 6: Information Theory

In ODC, the action is literally information content. The budget n = 282.84 bits limits the total information that can be processed. Every physical process trades energy and time for information according to the relation S = n − C_geom.

12.2: Correspondence Table

The following table systematizes the correspondence between ODC concepts and classical mechanics:

ODC CONCEPT	CLASSICAL MECHANICS EQUIVALENT
Informational Depth (n = 282.84)	Total Available Action Budget
Stability Harmonic (Σ = 278.13)	Effective Mechanical Potential
Configuration Space Q	Phase Space Submanifold
Resolution Manifold	Classical Trajectory
Instantaneous Throughput $L(q,\dot{q})$	Lagrangian L
Informational Cost S[q]	Action Functional S
Resolution Process	Stationary Action Extremization ($\delta S=0$)
Conjugate Momentum p	Generalized Momentum $\partial L/\partial\dot{q}$
Informational State (q,p)	Phase Space Point
Informational Gradient ($\partial L/\partial\dot{q}$)	Conjugate Momentum
Conservation Law (Noether)	Conserved Quantity Q
Time Symmetry	Energy Conservation
Space Symmetry	Momentum Conservation
Rotational Symmetry	Angular Momentum Conservation
Gauge Redundancy	Unobservable Configuration Equivalence
Field $\varphi(x,t)$	Classical Field
Lagrangian Density $\mathscr{L}$	Field Energy Density
Quantum Phase ($\phi = S/\hbar$)	Wavefunction Phase ∝ Action
Stationary Phase Limit	Classical Limit of Quantum Theory

12.3: The Deep Principle

At the deepest level, the action principle expresses a single profound truth:

> *Reality resolves along the path of minimal information cost.*

The observer is not passive. The observer is the resolution process. Every measurement, every observation, every quantum collapse is the observer navigating the information manifold, selecting the most economical trajectory through the space of possible resolutions.

The Lagrangian $L = T - V$ is the instantaneous informational throughput. Kinetic energy is the cost of processing information about motion. Potential energy is the cost imposed by the environment. Their difference is the NET throughput.

The action $S = \int L\, dt$ accumulates this throughput over time. Every worldline has a total cost. The observer selects the worldline that extremizes this cost—either minimizing it (in stable systems) or saddle-pointing (at phase transitions).

The Euler-Lagrange equations $\partial L/\partial q - d/dt(\partial L/\partial \dot{q}) = 0$ are the consistency conditions for this extremization. They are not laws imposed from outside. They are the shape of the information flow field itself.

Noether's theorem tells us that every continuous symmetry—every way the information landscape can be transformed without changing its fundamental structure—gives rise to a conserved charge. Energy, momentum, and angular momentum are the conserved charges of time translation, space translation, and rotational symmetry. They are not invented concepts. They emerge necessarily from the geometry of information.

The Hamiltonian formulation reveals phase space as the complete informational state. Liouville's theorem shows that informational capacity is conserved. The number of possible states does not grow or shrink. Information is eternal.

The Hamilton-Jacobi equation bridges classical and quantum. The action S is the phase of the quantum wavefunction. The classical path emerges as the path where the phase is stationary—the path of minimal quantum complexity.

Field theory extends this principle to infinitely many degrees of freedom. The action density $\mathscr{L}$ at each spacetime point determines how the field evolves. The equations of motion—Maxwell's equations, the Dirac equation, the Klein-Gordon equation, Einstein's field equations—all follow from this single principle of stationary action.

Nothing is more fundamental than the action principle in ODC. It is the answer to the question: why does reality have the laws that it has? Because any other configuration would require greater

informational cost. The universe simply follows the path of least resistance through the space of resolutions.

12.4: Closing Reflection

We have shown that from the single axiom of ODC—that conscious observation consumes information from a finite budget n—there flows the entire structure of classical mechanics, field theory, and the quantum-classical boundary.

The action principle is the membrane between quantum and classical. The Lagrangian is the lens through which observation focuses the infinite quantum possibilities into a single classical history.

Every particle that moves, every field that oscillates, every process that unfolds in the universe is a testimony to the principle of least action. It is written into the fabric of reality. It cannot be violated. It can only be understood, accepted, and marveled at.

For in the end, the action principle is not a law imposed upon nature. It IS nature itself—the most economical, the most elegant, the most inevitable solution to the problem: how does a conscious observer resolve reality from an ocean of quantum possibility?

The answer is: by following the path of stationary action.

About the Author

Kandarp Dalal is the creator of Observer-Dependent Cosmology and author of the Theory of Everything book series. A Data Engineer by profession, Dalal brings the rigor of information theory and signal processing to theoretical physics. His work reframes the foundations of mechanics from the perspective of information conservation and the conscious observer.

For inquiries: kandarpdalal.work@gmail.com